

# The Buddha's Alter Ego: The World Conquering Monarch

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Tips of the Day · 6 min read

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This year, 2024, will see scores of elections across the world! When the Buddha was born, eight soothsayers, eight wise men came to see him and seven of them said that he would either be a Self-Awakened Buddha or he would be a World Conquering Monarch. But one of them said, no, he's going to be a fully self-realized awakened Buddha and that's how his life panned out. He belonged to the Kshatriya class, which would be the warrior cast, the aristocracy, the ones who would have led people in war. The rulers! His close friends were all the same. He knew King Bimbisara of Magada on the Ganges and King Pasenadi towards the north in Kosala. And the others were all of his caste. So, he was very familiar with the politics of day which was moving away from a tribal system of choosing their headman to a hereditary monarchical system. As if it were his alter ego, the Buddha offers us a myth about a king who strides the world, overcoming all the other kings, the World Conquering Emperor. How is this Emperor created? One day an eight spoked wheel, an ancient Indian symbol of conquest, here adapted to the Buddha's story, a Dhammacakka – a Dhamma Wheel, appears in front of a king's balcony. His wise Councillor informs him that this appearance means he is to be the Cakkavattin, One Who Turns the Wheel. And this is to be achieved by following the Dhammacakka wherever it goes. So off he flies into the air with his four-fold army - his infantry, his archers, his chariots, and his elephants. And whenever he comes into a kingdom, the king there does not fight him. He sees that this is a glorious being and he's happy to become his vassal. This is what happened to the Sakka tribe that the Buddha was born into. They had been their own little grouping with their lands, as you may know, in North India, presently part of Nepal. But in time another tribe became more powerful and conquered them. So, they became vassals to the King of Kosala. This had happened to many of the smaller tribes. So, there's already there an inkling of what would happen if the Buddha had decided to become a Cakkavattin. Now a Cakkavattin has Seven Treasurers much as a Self-Awakened Buddha has Seven Factors of Enlightenment. So these include: A miracle wheel, the Dhammacakka A miracle horse which flies through the air A miracle elephant The miracle Gem that casts light for miles around The princess who is a beautiful woman of course. It is said her limbs are cool in the hot season and warm in the cool season A wise counsellor A successful commander. And so he becomes the Emperor of the whole world. After a lifetime of ruling the Dhammawheel begins to fade and the Emperor knows this is time for him to retire into a seclusive life. But his son does not necessarily become the next Cakkavattin. Yet the wheel does reappear to many of his descendants. But wherein lies the power of this Cakkavattin. He is so strong because of his morality, his ethics. He is committed to the Five Training Rules. And if you bring the first to mind - not to kill any living being, can you imagine what would happen in this world today if everyone took the First Precept only to

not kill a human being! And then there's not to steal. Not to use power or wealth to take advantage of people. Not abuse our sexual energy and the huge growth in the pornography industry. And then there's Wrong Speech and all the politicians who tell lies. And then there's not taking anything that is going to disturb clear mindedness. The Monarch also is imbued with the ten virtues, Dasa Raja Dhamma, described by the Buddha for a king. These are essential qualities that contribute to wise and compassionate governance. These virtues are: Generosity (Dāna): a king is generous and giving so people are grateful and loyal. Morality (Sīla): He maintains moral integrity that sets a positive example for the citizens. Sacrifice (Pariccāga): He is willing to make a personal sacrifice for the greater good. This shows his commitment to people's welfare. Straightness (Ajjava): He is honest and straightforward in his dealings and this promotes justice and trust. Gentleness (Maddava): He is a mild and gentle governor so reducing conflicts and enhancing peaceful relations. Self-control (Tapa): He practices self-restraint and self-discipline and so avoids indulgence. This allows him to focus on his duties. Non-anger (Akkodha): He is calm and not give in to anger, critical for making wise decisions. Non-violence (Avihimsa): He promotes harmlessness and non-violence, ensuring the safety and security of all beings. Patience (Khanti): He is endowed with forbearance and tolerance, vital for dealing with adversity and dissent. Non-opposition (Avirodhana): He is a committed advocate for non-conflict and harmony, aiming to resolve disputes amicably and maintain unity. These virtues, of course, not only guide the king in his governance but also serve as principles that can enhance the moral and social fabric of any society. So it is with this ethical integrity and moral authority that the Cakkavattin rules over the whole world. And this rule of peace and justice lasts through six Emperors. Then as always corruption sets in. The seventh Cakkavattin is not committed to the Five Precepts even though his counsellors warn him problems will follow. The first thing that happens is that greed begins to take over and poverty comes to the land. Then one day a person steals. And this is unheard of! So they bring this man to the court, the emperor asks him, why did you steal? And he says I'm poor. I need money to feed my family. I would be happy not to steal. So the king gives him money. But then the rumour spreads if you steal something, the king will give you lots of money. So theft grew. And it grew to a point where the king realised he has made a big mistake And so when the next thief comes along he has the man executed. Before long because of not sharing the wealth of the Empire all sorts of crimes are committed. And the discourse ends with no solution in sight. Once you let the demon out of the bottle, it's difficult to get it back in. But a reign of justice will begin when the next fully Self-Enlightened Buddha comes and he will be Ariya Metteya. According to canonical scriptures, Ariya Metteyya is the fifth in the lineage of Buddhas (Tathāgata) of the current aeon, and successor of the 28 Buddhas of the past. Ariya means "noble", and Metteyya is derived from the Pali word mātreyya which refers to "one's mother" and "motherloving". In real life the Buddha was involved in many political disputes such as stopping his clan going to war with the Koliya clan on the other side of a shared river. He was often asked for advice by kings and headmen, such as Ajatasattu. He was the young new king of Magadha who took the reins of the kingdom by starving his father to death. This kingdom was situated on the north side of the Ganges whose capital was present day Varanasi or Benaras as it was known in the Buddha's day. He sent a councilor, Brahmin Vassakara, to ask the Buddha if this was a good time to attack the Vajji Federation. This was a

federation of clans like the Buddha's who had not been conquered. The Buddha preferred this way of ruling so much so that he did not leave a successor but said that the Sangha should be guided by the Dhamma and the Vinaya (the Rule) he had left. The Buddha answers obliquely and simply lists seven reasons that keep a federation strong. "As long as the Vajjis meet frequently and have many meetings, they can expect growth, not decline." "As long as the Vajjis meet in harmony, leave in harmony, and carry on their business in harmony, they can expect growth, not decline." "As long as the Vajjis don't make new decrees or abolish existing decrees, but proceed having undertaken the ancient Vajjian traditions, their constitution, as they have been decreed, they can expect growth, not decline." "As long as the Vajjis honor, respect, esteem, and venerate Vajjian elders, and think them worth listening to, they can expect growth, not decline." "As long as the Vajjis don't forcibly abduct the women or girls of the clans and make them live with them, they can expect growth, not decline." "As long as the Vajjis honor, respect, esteem, and venerate the Vajjian shrines, whether inner or outer, not neglecting the proper spirit-offerings that were given and made in the past, they can expect growth, not decline." "As long as the Vajjis organize proper protection, shelter, and security for perfected ones, so that more perfected ones might come to the realm and those already here may live in comfort, they can expect growth, not decline." Vassakara went back to tell his king it was not a good time. However, the king set about undermining the harmony the kingdom with bribes and subterfuge, false tales, (fake news – there's nothing new!). The Federation began to break up and one day Ajatasattu simply walked in and absorbed it into his kingdom. So here and on many other occasions throughout his teaching life the Buddha was intimately involved in the politics of his day. He knew that his dispensation needed the support of the civil authorities, but more than that he cared for the whole society he lived in. And as our exemplar it behoves us to become involved in whatever way we can with our societies.

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